

Chickpea to Cook

Rumi – Translated by Coleman Barks

A chickpea leaps almost over the rim of the pot
where it's being boiled.

‘Why are you doing this to me?’

The cook knocks him down with the ladle.

‘Don’t you try to jump out.
You think I’m torturing you.
I’m giving you flavor,
so you can mix with spices and rice
and be the lovely vitality of a human being.

Remember when you drank rain in the garden.
That was for this.’

Grace first. Sexual pleasure,
then a boiling new life begins,
and the Friend has something good to eat.

Eventually the chickpea will say to the cook,
‘Boil me some more.
Hit me with the skimming spoon.
I can’t do this by myself.

The chickpea submits to the consequences by the Divine.
I'm like an elephant that dreams of gardens
back in Hindustan and doesn't pay attention
to his driver. You're my cook, my driver, my
way into existence. I love your cooking.'

The cook says,
'I was once like you,
fresh from the ground. Then I boiled in
time, and boiled in the body, two fierce
boilings.

My animal soul grew powerful.
I controlled it with practices,
and boiled some more, and
boiled once beyond that,
and became your teacher.'